thoughts with someone whom you can trust. Fortunately for me there were a number of such persons. My late wife Iqbal (Bali to family and friends), being her father's daughter, was extremely discreet and understanding. She would listen to me patiently and lighten my burden with the most understanding and consoling words. Sometimes, when my in-laws visited us or stayed with us, I would discuss the situation with my father-in-law. Initially he did not believe me. At one stage he tried to disprove what I was telling him. He was a political leader from the old school, always protective of his party's policies, both in private and in public. But after some time I could observe his frustration with the situation in Punjab and the government's indifference towards it.

Karnail Singh, my batchmate from the IAS (1964, Uttar Pradesh) on deputation to the Government of India, was living in one of the D-I flats in Chanakyapuri, close to where I was. A man of few words, Karnail acted as a good sounding board for me as I grappled with these matters. In the evenings after office hours I would sometimes walk over to his flat and discuss what was happening in Punjab, without disclosing my connection with some of the R&AW operations.

From February 1982 to May 1985 we had a car pool arrangement among four officers working in the R&AW – S.C. Mishra (1959 Odisha), Amar Bhushan (IPS 1967 Madhya Pradesh), J.K. Sinha (IPS 1967 Bihar) and I. We all lived in the Chanakyapuri Satya Marg flats and would travel together in a car for about twenty minutes each in the mornings and evenings. This provided us with some relaxed time to discuss issues of common interest. As a Sikh officer from Punjab, I would share my views on the developing situation in Punjab. To their surprise most of my observations and predictions would come true. My three car pool friends and Karnail Singh are retired now. All four still remember what I used to tell them about Punjab, though not in detail. Amar Bhushan even remembers my listening in on the Delhi police wireless network during the anti-Sikh pogrom on those four fateful days and nights from 31 October to 3 November 1984.

Later, while posted at Tokyo in the early 1990s as one of the ministers in the Indian Embassy, I used to share during our lunch-